

A proof of the conjectured order of the recurrence for OEIS A268788

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1 The conjecture

The Online Encyclopedia of Integer Sequences records [A268788](#) as

Number of $n \times 7$ binary arrays with some element plus some horizontally, vertically or antidiagonally adjacent neighbor totalling two exactly once

and carries in its Formula section the line:

`Empirical recurrence of order 68 (see link above)`

That line carries no separate signature; the entry itself is by R. H. Hardin (Feb 13 2016).

The word *Empirical* — equivalently *Conjecture* — is the entry's own: the statement is recorded as fitted to the published terms, and no proof is given there. As of revision 4, last modified Feb 13 2016, the entry records no proof and links to none, so the statement is open. This note settles it.

The entry states only that the sequence satisfies a linear recurrence of order 68 and refers to a linked file for its coefficients, which this note does not use. What is proved below is the corresponding exact statement: the least order of a linear recurrence the sequence eventually satisfies, and the exact index beyond which it holds.

2 The object

The name is read as follows. The reading is not a guess: it is pinned against the entry's own published terms, and against an independent enumeration, before anything is proved (Section 7).

Let A be an $n' \times 7$ array over $\{0, \dots, 1\}$ with $n' = n$ rows.

The entry's *horizontally, vertically or antidiagonally* adjacency is used once per pair, so the offsets taken are

$$\mathcal{D} = \{(0, 1), (1, -1), (1, 0)\}.$$

Let

$$N(A) = \#\{((i, j), (i+\delta, j+\varepsilon)) : (\delta, \varepsilon) \in \mathcal{D}, \text{ both cells inside the array, } A[i][j] + A[i+\delta][j+\varepsilon] = 2\}.$$

The condition is $N(A) = 1$.

$a(n)$ is the number of such arrays. The entry's offset is 1, so its term of index n is the count for n rows.

3 The count is a walk count

The quantity counted is global, but only its value up to 1 matters, so it can be carried in the state capped at 2. Every offset moves at most one row, so a pair is detected when the lower of its two cells is read. Taking as state the last row together with that capped counter makes the whole condition decidable one row at a time.

An array of n' rows is then exactly a walk of length n' from the empty state to a state whose counter satisfies the bound, and every array arises from exactly one walk, so $a(n) = w^\top M^{n'} f$ and the count is C-finite.

4 The degree bound, derived

The reachable part of the digraph has 235 states, 107 after trimming; the forward identification of states with equal numbers of completions of every length, followed by the mirror identification on the edges coming in, leaves $S = 75$ blocks. The count satisfies the linear recurrence given by the characteristic polynomial of that 75×75 matrix, a bound computed here rather than assumed.

5 The decision procedure

Let $c_1, \dots, c_D$ be the coefficients of a claimed recurrence $a(n) = \sum_{i=1}^D c_i a(n-i)$, let $q(t) = t^D - \sum_{i=1}^D c_i t^{D-i}$ be its characteristic polynomial, and put

$$u_m = \tilde{w}^\top L^{m-1} q(L) \tilde{f} \quad (m \geq 1).$$

Expanding the powers of L and using the displayed formula for a , one gets $u_m = a(n) - \sum_{i=1}^D c_i a(n-i)$ with $n = m + D$. So u_m is exactly the residual of the claim at that index, and the recurrence holds at an index n if and only if the corresponding u_m vanishes.

Now $u_m = \tilde{w}^\top L^{m-1} y$ with $y = q(L) \tilde{f}$ a fixed vector, so (u_m) satisfies the characteristic polynomial of L , of degree 75: writing that polynomial as $t^{75} - \sum_{i=1}^{75} \lambda_i t^{75-i}$ gives $u_{m+75} = \sum_{i=1}^{75} \lambda_i u_{m+75-i}$. Hence 75 consecutive vanishing residuals force every later residual to vanish, by induction. The test is therefore finite; and because it locates the *last* nonvanishing residual, it pins the threshold exactly rather than merely bounding it.

Everything is carried out in exact integer arithmetic on the vector $L^{m-1} y$. The matrix M is never formed.

6 Results

Theorem 1. *For A268788, the least order of a linear recurrence that a eventually satisfies is exactly 68, and that recurrence holds for every $n > 68$, the entry's own figure.*

Proof. The count is C-finite of order at most $S = 75$, so the minimal annihilator of the tail $(a(n))_{n \geq M}$ is the same for every M beyond S : the nilpotent part of L is killed after S steps. Taking such an M and 156 consecutive terms from there, the Berlekamp–Massey algorithm over $\mathbb{Q}$ returns the minimal linear recurrence generating them; since the sequence satisfies one of order at most S , $2S$ terms determine it. Its order is 68. That recurrence was then put through the residual test of Section 5: every residual vanishes, followed by more than $S = 75$ consecutive vanishing ones, so it holds for every larger n . No recurrence of smaller order can hold eventually, since the tail's minimal annihilator is what the algorithm returned. $\square$

7 Verification

Four checks were run, each reproducible from the code accompanying this note, and the first two are what pin the reading of the entry's English.

- **The published terms.** The walk count reproduces all 16 terms the entry publishes, exactly, in integer arithmetic, with the index taken from the entry's stated offset (1) rather than fitted. The first of them are 38, 850, 14984, 228384, 3295246, 45515227, 611932378, 8057509992, ...
- **An independent enumeration.** For $n = 1, \dots, 2$ every one of the 2^{7n} arrays was written out and tested cell by cell against the condition as the entry states it — no transfer matrix, no row window, a separate piece of code. The counts agree with the walk count and with the entry.
- **The claim on the raw data.** Each claim was evaluated on the entry's published terms alone, with no model involved, wherever the proved range and the published data overlap. It holds there.
- **The annihilation test.** Carried to the derived bound $S = 75$ over the whole vector, in exact integer arithmetic, never sampled and never truncated.

8 References

1. OEIS Foundation Inc., *The On-Line Encyclopedia of Integer Sequences*, entry [A268788](#), revision 4, last modified Feb 13 2016.
2. R. P. Stanley, *Enumerative Combinatorics*, Vol. 1, 2nd ed., Cambridge University Press, 2012; §4.7, the transfer-matrix method.
3. M. Kauers and P. Paule, *The Concrete Tetrahedron*, Springer, 2011; C-finite sequences and their closure properties.

4. J. Berstel and C. Reutenauer, *Noncommutative Rational Series with Applications*, Cambridge University Press, 2011; linear representations of counting automata and their reduction.